FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE
CONTACT: PEJ Deputy Director Amy Mitchell at 202.419.3650

2009 PEJ Raw Data Sets Now Available Online

Thursday, July 1—The Pew Research Center's Project for Excellence in Journalism is pleased to release the 2009 News Coverage Index raw data set and toplines of additional content analysis reports. The data are now available to scholars for use in their research and can be downloaded on PEJ's website at http://www.journalism.org/by_the_numbers/datasets.

The News Coverage Index (NCI)—The NCI captures and analyzes some 50 news outlets in real time to determine what is being covered and what is not in the U.S. news media. The NCI launched in January 2007 and has run continuously since. Weekly findings are released every Tuesday in a concise narrative that charts the top stories of the week, trajectory of the coverage and differences among media sectors. In all, the 2009 NCI sample includes 55 outlets, every Monday through Sunday. The key variables include source, story date, big story, broad story topic, placement, format, geographic focus, story word count, duration of broadcast story and lead newsmaker. The outlets studied come from print, network TV, cable, online, and radio. They include evening and morning network news, several hours of daytime and prime time cable news each day, newspapers from around the country, the top online news sites, and radio, including headlines, long form programs and talk.

Additional reports—PEJ offers topline data for additional content-based reports. The focus of these opportunistic studies ranged from how the media covered the Great Recession to President Obama's first 100 days in office and much more.

The 2009 NCI data set totals 68,717 stories: 7,370 newspaper stories, 7,830 online stories, 19,427 stories from network television, 18,856 stories on cable news, and 15,234 stories from radio programs. The data set is offered in SPSS through the use of zip files and is accompanied by the coding scheme and other explanatory material. In addition, toplines from six additional studies are included as PDF files. PEJ makes data sets of the Index available in a yearly basis. The 2007 data set was released in July 2008 and the 2008 data set was released in July 2009. And data from 2010 will be available in July of 2011.

The News Coverage Index was designed by PEJ Director Tom Rosenstiel and Deputy Director Amy Mitchell and an advisory team of nine academic and commercial researchers, including Steve Lacy of the Michigan State University, Esther Thorson of the University of Missouri—Columbia and Dan Riffe of University of North Carolina—Chapel Hill. It required the creation of proprietary software and a new website. The index report is written by PEJ Associate Director Mark Jurkowitz. The coding team of sixteen professionals works 24 hours behind the news cycle. They work with Content Supervisor, Paul Hitlin, Supervising Research Methodologist, Hong Ji, Content & Training Coordinator, Mahvish Shahid Khan and Weekly News Index Manager, Tricia Sartor.

PEJ, which is non-partisan and non-political, is one of seven projects that make up the Pew Research Center in Washington, D.C., a "fact tank" funded by the Pew Charitable Trusts.